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LIONS IN GUJARAT

A NEW HOME FOR THE LIONS

Visavadar stations in Bhavnagar division was opposed by lion experts.

The debate around industrialisation and development, tourism included, and wildlife conservation is an old one. The new Una Wildlife Park is being criticised for prioritising tourism—and the attendant increase in vehicular movement and tourism-related urbanisation—over conservation, and for fencing in a free-ranging lion population.

A member of the Mitiyala Gir Sanctuary Advisory Committee, Chaitanya Joshi, wrote to the Central Zoo Authority, urging it to turn down the Gujarat government's proposal for a new wildlife park, implying that it would be a fenced zoo and arguing that it is being carved out of precious reserve forest. "The area is integral to the 'southern-western coastal satellite home' (for lions) and a breeding ground for lionesses as it is a compact patch of forest...the only forest patch left in the region. The population acts as a source population for free-ranging lions in this coastal belt," he wrote. Such projects, says Joshi, should be developed in barren land that doesn't eat into the existing natural movement area for lions and associated species. "We are already falling short of such areas, and don't have any new areas left for wild lions in this entire landscape," the letter urges.

For perspective, lion movement is spread over a 30,000 sq. km area, of which only 3,500 sq. km is forested—vital for the wild population of lions. The rest is covered by agricultural land, grazing land, villages and even towns.



Bhushan Pandya, former member of the state board for wildlife, says the Greater Gir region where lion populations have been spotted require a management plan, backed by a vision of how populations will increase and where the lions will go. "We do not want the lions to become captive in the wild. Fragmenting natural corridors with railway lines and highways will not only increase the risk of accidents, but will lead to more territorial fights, inbreeding and consequently rise in deadly diseases," says Pandya, who has often flagged concerns over the indiscriminate expansion of the railway network passing through known lion territories.

Srivastava, however, is confident of balancing industrial development and wildlife conservation. "The blueprint for development here is to prioritise wildlife. A culvert or a high underpass or a wide overpass is constructed when roads or railway lines pass through lion corridors. Our doctors are national experts on lion behaviour and medical intervention. We are conserving three gene pools in isolated locations," he counters.

The Union government has sanctioned Rs 2,900 crore as part of Project Lion for various conservation activities. Much of this is being utilised in initiatives to educate local people about the behaviour of lions, while using drones, electronic collars and CCTV cameras for monitoring lions. In the first week of November, Gujarat chief minister Bhupendra Patel released a web app called 'Sinh Suchna'. The app will provide exact, real-time information about the location and movement of lions.

Meanwhile, the decade-old Supreme Court order directing the translocation of some lions from Gir to another distant habitat to develop an independent population is gathering dust. The state government is currently seeking to balance agriculture, industrialisation and tourism development with wildlife conservation of an endangered species. ■